



Preamble

We are in -25805 before the Battle of Yavin IV. At this time, most known species are still underdeveloped. Hyperspace travel is only a dream, and the Republic is just a meaningless word.

The Jedi Order and the Sith Lords do not exist. The terms dark side and light side mean nothing. It is in the heart of the galaxy, in a region called the Deep Core, that the Je'daii Order was born.

This order, which conducts research on the Force, is both respected and feared by the rest of the inhabitants of its solar system. Proud of their powers and scientific discoveries, the Je'daii are unaware that a growing threat is at work in the very heart of their solar system and could well challenge their supremacy...

Chapter 1 - History Lesson

"Did you feel it too?"

"Yes."

"Should I inform the others, Father?"

"No, it's unnecessary. What we felt is not a command but an invitation. It is up to each one to accept or decline it. Go, prepare your things and follow me if you wish to join the Pyramid."

We are on Ando Prime, the original planet of the Dai Bendu monk order, long before the creation of the first Galactic Republic. The order is exclusively composed of Talids, humanoid beings with stocky bodies recognizable by their two legs and four slender arms ending in a hand with three fingers, including an opposable thumb. Their hair was straight, long, white, or blonde, adorned with pearls or bones indicating their social status. The men sported beards of the same color as their hair. Finally, the tip of their snout had four nostrils.

The entire Order felt this mysterious call, and all responded. They crossed the freezing cold and snowstorms of their world to reach the Pyramid. Once there, the head of the order turned to face his people and shouted:

"My brothers, my sisters, our vision is coming true! The Pyramid has awakened and invites us to enter! It is time for our people to follow their destiny and leave this planet."

They all entered the Pyramid. The same phenomenon occurred in various places across the galaxy, like Kashyyyk, Dathomir, Ryloth, and Manaan, the home planets of the Wookies, Zabrak, Twi'leks, and Selkaths, respectively. A total of eight pyramids scattered across the galaxy awakened. These remnants from another time, which were actually spacecraft, took off. They all converged at the center of the galaxy, in the region called the Deep Core. At the center of this region was a massive black hole. The gravitational pull of this entity was such that it distorted space-time around the Deep Core, causing collisions in hyperspace lanes, making hyperspace travel difficult and dangerous. The eight spacecraft crossed the Deep Core and joined a ninth pyramid on the planet Tython.

These eight monoliths began to orbit around the ninth, suddenly stopped, and sped off to the four corners of Tython. This event triggered terrible Force storms across the planet's surface. Thus ended the first exodus.

Once landed, the colonists united under one banner, the Je'daii Order. Je'daii came from the Dai Bendu language and meant "mystical center." Gradually, the dream of the promised land turned into a nightmare. Not all descendants of the first colonists inherited the gift of sensing the Force. Life on Tython was impossible without a good mastery of the Force. Then the first disasters occurred. On this planet, the flora and fauna are hostile, and even more so against those insensitive to the Force: the law of the strongest governs life on Tython, and the weak have no place. Thus, disasters occurred all over the planet for over a millennium. The destruction of the city of Aurum then occurred, by far the deadliest catastrophe recorded until then. Many Je'daii lost their lives, and among the victims were a large majority of non-Force-sensitives. Following this carnage, the Je'daii council banned non-Force-sensitives from Tython to protect them. Families, men and women, brothers and sisters were separated for their safety. The expatriates found refuge on other planets in the system. Thus took place the second exodus and the colonization of the entire Tythosian system.

"And since then, we continue to respect the rule banning non-Force-sensitives from Tython to protect them."

All the young padawans widened their eyes at this revelation about their past. They looked at Ranger Terra, who had just told them the story, and felt a flood of questions overwhelm them.

"Ranger Terra, the 'Pyramids' you mentioned, are they the nine Tho Yor?"

"Exactly, young padawan, and near each one, a Je'daii temple practicing a specific discipline was built."

Immediately, another padawan hurried to ask a new question:

"But why did our ancestors call them 'Pyramids'? They don't really look like pyramids?"

Hearing this remark, the Ranger couldn't help but smile and replied:

"Good observation! At the time, when our ancestors discovered the ships, most were half-buried, looking like pyramids. This term has endured through the ages, and we continue to call them that. However, I admit that these ships look more like two pyramids glued together, one on top of the other."

The same padawan asked the master again:

"There is something I don't understand. How can a ship invite people to enter it? And besides, how could the ship contact them? It's a ship; it can't shout!"

Ranger Terra stifled a laugh at the candor of this question and the incredulous expression on the child's face.

"That's the whole mystery! We know that the Tho Yor communicated via the Force. Thus, you guessed it, all our ancestors who boarded were Force-sensitive. However, the Tho Yor remain an enigma. We do not know who their creators are, why they were created, and how they function."

The master paused, then, before new questions appeared in the minds of the Je'daii Initiates, he declared:

"Young people, today's lesson is over; you can leave the room."

Without further ado and without a word, the group of young students left the room at a leisurely pace. Ranger Terra was at Padawan Kesh, the Je'daii academy on Tython. The temple was cubic in shape. From the main entrance, two visible corners had cylindrical stone columns as tall as the façade. At each rear corner of the building, an imposing stone structure adjoined. These two monoliths were several meters taller than the main structure and ended in majestic golden peaks. Above the cubic shape were various administrative buildings covered in gold, reflecting the powerful and glorious Je'daii Order. Several dozen meters above the temple floated one of the nine Tho Yor. Imposing, majestic, mysterious.

Ranger Terra left the classroom located in the right wing column of the temple and walked through the long corridors lit by small white lights. Despite their small size and the space between each, the light they emitted was bright and allowed clear visibility. The Je'daii was heading towards the back of the temple to reach his ship situated further away. He then saw Ilan Koda and his wife, Talia Koda, accompanied by Ruhr, a Wookiee. The couple and Olga had been longtime friends. They met at the Je'daii academy and formed close bonds of friendship during their Great Journey. Ilan was a light-skinned Zabrak. Without his horns, he could be mistaken for a human. His wife, Talia, was a pure-blood human. She had long, curly red hair giving her a slightly warrior-like appearance. As for Ruhr, he was the Master of the Padawan Kesh temple, holding the second highest rank in the Je'daii Order. He had brown fur, with braided hair and beard. As soon as

the master saw the ranger, he interrupted his conversation with the couple, headed towards the temple entrance, and passed by Olga Terra with disdain. At that moment, Talia noticed Ranger Terra and called out:

"Olga! What a pleasure to see you again!"

He smiled broadly:

"The pleasure is shared! What brings you to Padawan Kesh?"

"As always, our daughter Shae," replied Talia.

"I thought your last meeting with Master Ruhr had ended his resentment towards you," Ilan said, saddened by the situation.

"Tell us about your last mission instead," the Je'daii quickly interjected to change the subject.

"It was a diplomatic mission. The goal was to defuse a conflict on Ska Gora between the Wookies who colonized the forests and the population living in city-ships. Through negotiation, we finally found common ground and avoided a conflict on the planet. And you, who were you tracking this time?"

"We were following a smuggler tasked with supplying poisoned food and then selling overpriced medicine. We intercepted him on one of Kalimahr's moons, but..."

Talia sighed deeply, and Ilan finished the story for her:

"There were complications, and we had no choice but to eliminate him."

Seeing the disappointment in their friend's eyes, Ilan continued:

"I know how much you advocate diplomacy and reject violence, but sometimes negotiation isn't enough..."

They greeted each other, and Ranger Terra continued on his way to his ship. He raised his left arm, pressed a button on his bracelet, and brought his wrist close to his mouth:

"C4R0, do you read me?"

A long silence followed. The Ranger sighed and resumed:

"C4R0L1N3, do you read me?"

Then a loud crash broke the silence, probably a crate being knocked over. The sound of a droid wheel speeding could be heard. In response, Olga heard a series of clicks.

"Okay, prepare the ship, I'm coming. We're making a stop at Anil Kesh, and then we'll go to Stav Kesh."

He ended the communication. The Je'daii rolled his eyes in exasperation and said aloud to himself:

"I don't understand why droid manufacturers give such long names to their creations! It's not that complicated to limit it to four characters! Damn Noxians! Incapable of doing simple things!"

He sighed and resumed:

"There must be a mechanic capable of making this adjustment at Anil Kesh!"

He was far from knowing how pertinent his remark was.

Between each of his missions, Olga loved spending time at Anil Kesh to learn about the latest scientific advancements, at Stav Kesh for martial arts training and the Temple of Silence, where his mentor resided. All nine temples were located on Tython.

The Je'daii continued on his way to his ship. The weather was magnificent. The ground was covered with Nakaimi, a strangely soft grass no more than ten centimeters high. The landscape was dotted with various tree species, including Burokko. These trees had a thin trunk and ended in a rather dense network of branches. The foliage was quite extensive, providing large shaded areas. It was not uncommon for Je'daii to come here to meditate. The leaves of this tree were hand-sized and had the peculiarity of turning from khaki to rust when the balance in the Force was disturbed.

Olga arrived in front of his ship. It was a Peacemaker-class cruiser, reserved for Je'daii on long-distance missions. It could travel quickly between planets but did not reach the speed of light. Moreover, technological advances, so dear to Olga, still did not allow ships to travel at light speed or in hyperspace. This cruiser was elongated and coal-black. On either side of the ship were two laser cannons towards the front, each mounted on a head capable of rotating one hundred and eighty degrees. At the top was a turret capable of rotating three hundred and sixty degrees. It could be operated in two ways. The first method involved using the targeting helmet and firing lever. The second was an Anil Kesh invention, usable only by Force-sensitive beings. It involved wearing a helmet connected by numerous cables to the control panel. The helmet had an opaque visor blocking the wearer's view. The inside of the helmet was filled with Force sensors. Thus, all firing, targeting, and reloading instructions were transmitted mentally.

Under the main compartment were also mounted laser cannons. At the rear of the ship were two wings, perpendicular to the body. They started their course at the top of the structure and ended a few meters later near the ground. On them was painted the red symbol of the Je'daii Order. The vessel was registered as "The Perseverant."

C4R0 was at the top of the ramp. This droid was specially designed to assist Je'daii in maneuvering and maintaining their ships. She was a CLP-TR3 type droid, about eighty centimeters tall, bronze and rust-colored. Here and there, blue metal plates were fixed, likely repairs from overly aggressive negotiations. Unusually, the droid had a feminine programming tendency. On each side of the top of the robot was an antenna, the right one being a mechanical arm and the left a high-frequency sensor and receiver. Its large cylindrical torso was dotted with indicators and buttons. It had a central wheel for movement, with a metal rod ending in a small wheel on either side of the lower part of its trunk, providing stability during turns or direction changes.

Olga went straight to the ship's cockpit, followed by C4.

"C4R0L1N3, raise the ramp, we're taking off for Anil Kesh."

The Persevering left the island of Masara, home to the Padawan Kesh and Bodhi temples, the Temple of Arts. Anil Kesh, the Temple of Science, was located on the Talss continent, the largest on Tython. The ship flew over the Deep Ocean and arrived north of the temple.

"C4R0L1N3, establish connection with the control tower."

In response, clicks were heard. He said aloud:

"This is the Persevering to control tower, requesting permission to dock."

"... This is the control tower, request granted, please dock at platform L41."

"Very well, C4R0L1N3, activate the stabilizers and deploy the landing gear, we are going to land."

Olga opened the ramp and addressed C4 again:

"Come with me this time; we'll take the opportunity to update you and make some adjustments..."

Around them were numerous similar platforms. They took the corridor leading to the temple. Upon reaching the platform, the Je'daii was once again struck with admiration. The sight before him was breathtaking. In front of the Je'daii stood a volcanic chain stretching for dozens of kilometers. Some volcanoes were still active, and it was not uncommon for

them to erupt when the balance in the Force was disturbed. But the most impressive sight was ahead. An immense rift seemed almost surreal in this already supernatural landscape. The further east one moved, the deeper the fissure. To the far east of this rift was Anil Kesh. On this section of the fissure, the two land masses rose. They were high and steep enough to make any climbing attempt nearly impossible.

The temple was a technological marvel, undoubtedly one of the greatest challenges faced by the Je'daii. Three large arches, equidistant from each other, were placed on the edges of the rift. These immense legs supported a circular structure above the deep chasm. It housed numerous rooms like laboratories, libraries, experimental rooms, and storage hangars. From the lower part of the temple emanated a white beam of light that continuously illuminated the Abyss to collect samples and data. The Tho Yor orbited the temple in mysterious circles.

The Abyss. This is what the Je'daii called the deepest part of the fissure. This cavity fascinated and frightened the Tythonians equally. The beam of light emitted by the temple seemed entirely swallowed by the darkness reigning in the Abyss. There was an eerie, unsettling, indecipherable sensation emanating from this place. It always took several days to get used to these sensations and no longer be disturbed by them. Strangely, only Force-sensitive beings were affected. The deeper one plunged into the Abyss, the stronger and more overwhelming the sensation. Many researchers dedicated their lives to studying this phenomenon. The boldest Je'daii ventured inside. Most never returned, and the few who did came back completely mad. To this day, the mystery remains...

The steep walls of the fissure had magnetic properties strong enough to disrupt conventional objects using the poles' magnetism. Following the study of this property, Anil Kesh scientists developed a shuttle capable of scaling the steep wall. This shuttle was magnetically attached to the landmass, in permanent levitation a few meters from it. Magnets placed in various parts of the craft allowed it to move horizontally and vertically. Each of the three temple arches had a docking platform for the shuttle, which could transport a hundred people.

Olga reached the platform where the shuttle was already present. He greeted nearby Je'daii with a brief nod, and some returned the gesture. He boarded and took a seat, followed by C4. The journey went smoothly, and

the shuttle docked at the north arch. They both disembarked, ascended the arch, and took the wide walkway leading to the heart of the temple. From there, the Abyss was even more terrifying. The landing platform they walked on overlooked this vast darkness swept by the wind. The Je'daii and his droid crossed the passage and arrived in the temple's reception hall.

It was a spacious circular hall. The ceiling was dome-shaped. Many Je'daii were present, some busy with their tasks, others simply sitting and watching the strange ballet of their colleagues. This was likely a way for them to take a break from their research. Still others were absorbed in passionate discussions, so much so that it was obvious they were unaware of the number of people around them.

Finding someone in this chaos was impossible. Ranger Terra calmed himself and closed his eyes. He was looking for someone in particular and located them in one of the lower-level laboratories. He headed there unhurriedly. These places fascinated him. On every floor and in every laboratory, experiments of all kinds were conducted, many focused on the Force. He continued walking along these corridors. Traces of explosions could be seen around some doors, likely the unexpected results of overly ambitious experiments. Olga stopped in front of a heavily reinforced door, metal supports here and there, layers unknown.

Before he could knock, the door opened, and a Sith greeted him with a broad smile:

"Olga! It's a pleasure to see you! Please, come in. We are about to test a prototype, I promise it's safe!"

"The pleasure is shared, my friend! Are you sure? Last time you said that, we almost didn't make it!"

"There can't be scientific revolution without breaking a few pots!" the Sith replied with a hearty laugh.

"I think before your demonstration, could you update my droid and make sure it responds to C4 and C4R0 as well?"

"Oh, what an unusual request! Yes, that should be possible..."

With a glance, he urged a colleague to take care of the droid. The latter left the laboratory with the robot. Antmoris Banes closed the door and addressed Olga again:

"As you know, we are not the first inhabitants of this planet. Before us were the Gree and the Kwa. And we must admit, they left us a lot of relics and

artifacts! However, for most of them, we can't even say which species they belonged to or from which time period they came. For this reason, we developed a device capable of dating an object, an artifact, a structure. In short, a gadget able to tell when it was created and possibly by whom."

"If your device proves itself, we could date the Tho Yors and find out who their creators are!"

"Exactly! Well, enough talk, let's get to practice."

They both approached the experimental table. Je'daii Banes then took the promising device in his left hand. This prototype was rectangular. Above the grip was a small screen, currently in standby mode. Opposite this screen was a small opening. Overall, the tool resembled a blaster.

On the experimental table were various objects. Olga recognized some Je'daii weapons, tools from mining planets, some Gree and Kwa artifacts, and others whose origins he couldn't guess.

The scientist aimed, targeted a Je'daii katana, and pressed the trigger. A beam of white light shot from the opening and hit the weapon.

"Once the laser is fixed on the desired object, you need to stay still for a few seconds. If after this time the device emits a 'ding' as it just did, it has determined at least one piece of information."

Antmoris looked at the small screen on the back of the device and continued:

"It identified the civilization and the period it belongs to!"

The Sith proceeded similarly with the present objects and finished with a Gree artifact:

"Hmm, still nothing... In this case, if it finds nothing after the few seconds of stillness, you need to slowly move the laser over the object to allow it to gather more information. After ten seconds, if it still can't determine anything, a different sound is emitted, as it just did... Well, it's still a prototype, but the more data we provide it, the more accurate it will become!" he explained hopefully.

Olga was about to ask if other inventions were in testing when his bracelet started ringing. Seeing who was calling, he suddenly went pale, casting a distressed look at his friend.

"Olga, are you alright? Who's calling?"

Seeing his interlocutor was petrified, the Sith grabbed his wrist and looked. It was Master Teelat. He was not in the habit of contacting Je'daii masters

directly, let alone Rangers. Seeing this name, the Sith's heart pounded. He quickly calmed himself and shook his friend:

"Answer! If you don't, it will be even worse!"

"And if he's calling because he's lost patience? I don't want to end up exiled on Ashla or Bogan!"

"You don't know what he wants, so answer!" Banes said firmly.

The Je'daii gathered his courage and accepted the call. Every muscle in his body was tense. His throat tightened, and he felt a weight in his stomach. He immediately knelt and bowed deeply.

"Master Telaat... It is an honor," Olga stammered, his voice filled with respect and fear.

"Raise your head, Ranger. Your presence is required at Akar Kesh as soon as possible," he said authoritatively.

"Yes, Master."

Without another word, the master ended the communication.

To be continued...